

Texas WIC Health and Human Services Commission

Effective: October 1, 2025

Policy No. CS:02.0

Timeframes for Processing Applicants

Purpose

To provide program benefits expediently to individuals requesting services.

Authority

7 CFR Part 246.7 (f) (2) (ii) (iii)

Policy

The Local Agency (LA) must process applicants within specific time frames at the time services are requested.

Definitions

Processing - screening, determining (in)eligibility, notifying applicants of their (in)eligibility or placement on a waiting list, and/or issuing food benefits to eligible applicants.

Migrant farm worker - an individual whose principal employment is in agriculture on a seasonal basis, who has been so employed within the last 24 months, and who establishes, for the purpose of such employment, a temporary abode.

External incoming referrals – services requested via electronic submission for WIC application. Examples include:

- **Self-referrals** – an individual submits information to begin the eligibility process for WIC services.
- **Outreach referrals** – LA conducts outreach events and provides individuals with the ability to request WIC services.
- **Healthcare provider referrals** – the healthcare provider office submits a referral to WIC for the family.

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Procedures

- I. Applicants requesting services (e.g., external incoming referrals in person, over the phone, etc.) must be processed within the following timeframes:
 - A. Pregnant women and members of migrant household who state they will be leaving the LA's service area within 30 days, must be processed within 10 calendar days of the date they first request program benefits. The State Agency (SA) may grant an extension of the 10-day processing time frame to a maximum of 15 calendar days for LAs who submit a written justification.
 - B. All other applicants must be processed within 20 calendar days of the date they first request program benefits.
- II. External incoming referrals via the WIC MIS, refer to definition above, must meet the processing time frames in Procedure I. A. and B. Clinic staff will review, and process external incoming referrals received through the WIC MIS. Clinic staff will confirm the clinic calendar allows appointments within the processing time frames.
 - A. When the clinic calendar has appointments that meet the processing time frames, staff may proactively schedule the client's appointment or use the client's preferred method of contact and notify the individual to schedule the appointment by contacting the clinic or using the participant portal.
 - B. When the clinic calendar does not have appointments that meet the processing time frames, staff will contact the client and offer an appointment that meets the processing time frame at their clinic or another clinic within their local agency.
- III. LA staff must select the appropriate reason from the MIS dropdown list for an appointment that exceeds the 10 to 20 calendar days.

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Appointments rescheduled by the applicant are an exception to the 10 to 20 calendar days requirement. Exceed reasons include:

- A. Client Preference – client requests an appointment that exceeds the 10 to 20 calendar days.
 - B. No Clinic Availability – This option is when the clinic or any clinic within the LA does not have appointments available that meets the 10 to 20 calendar days.
 - C. State Waiver – the LA has received a state waiver extension to the timeframe from 10 calendar days to 15 calendar days (see procedure I.A).
- IV. Appointments for recertification must be on or before the certification expiration date of the current certification period.
- V. Unless the participant has already received benefits for the month, the LA must issue benefits to participants at the same time they are notified of their eligibility.